

Entry Submission

Every field of the Innovation Award entry form, answered in full and in the same order as the form.

Project details

NAME OF ENTRANT

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STATUS OF PROJECT

☐ Concept / Idea ☒ Start-up☐ Existing business

NAME OF COMPANY

Buffr Financial Services CC

REGISTRATION NUMBER

CC/2024/09322

CO-FOUNDER

Etuna Fillemon John Nekwaya, technical operations and site rollout

Name of innovation

Checkpoint by Buffr

Private, encrypted guest and visitor check-in for hotels, lodges and tourism reception desks. Live at buffrcheckpoint.com.

Submission summary

Checkpoint by Buffr replaces the shared paper guest register at hotels, lodges and tourism reception desks with one private, encrypted record for each guest. Guests check in on their own phone by scanning a printed QR code at reception. Guests without a smartphone check in with the receptionist on a private screen. A property can also place an optional Android tablet at reception that shows the QR code and lets guests check themselves in. Hosts are notified, managers see who is on the property at any moment, and every sensitive action leaves an audit trail.

The platform is live at buffrcheckpoint.com. Hotel Etuna, our family's hotel in Ongwediva, is the first pilot site, and any property can sign up online and go live once its first payment clears.

What problem does the innovation solve?

A shared guest book exposes every guest to the next one. Namibian law requires every registered accommodation establishment to keep a guest register. On arrival, the establishment must record each guest's name, citizenship or country of residence, permanent postal address, vehicle registration, next destination and signature, among other details, and submit monthly returns to the Namibia Tourism Board. Failing to keep the register is an offence (Regulations Relating to the Registration of Accommodation Establishments, 2004, reg. 29). At many properties that register is still a bound book on the counter, so each guest who signs can read the lines above: names, addresses, phone numbers, car registrations and room numbers. Nobody knows who has looked at the book or photographed a page.

We have lived this problem. We grew up in hospitality and tourism. Our family runs Hotel Etuna in Ongwediva, formerly Etuna Guesthouse and Tours, and we have worked that front desk. We have watched guests read the page while they sign, and seen the book become the only record when the power fails.

The law protecting that information is still being written. Namibia does not yet have a data protection Act. In January 2026 the Data Protection Bill was reported ready for resubmission to the Cabinet Committee on Legislation after consultations closed (New Era, 2026), and the Minister of Information and Communication Technology had earlier described it as being in its final stages (Namibia Press Agency, 2025). Properties collect personal details under a legal duty today, with no privacy standard yet in force to guide how they protect them. Checkpoint gives them that standard now.

The scale is national. Tourism contributed N\$14.3 billion, or 6.9 percent of gross domestic product, in 2022 and directly employed 57,571 people (Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism & Namibia Statistics Agency, 2023). The Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism counted 1,217,108 international arrivals in 2025, and national parks recorded 994,780 visits (Business Express, 2026). Every one of those guests passes through a front desk.

What Checkpoint does about it. Each guest or visitor gets one isolated, encrypted record that only authorised staff can open. A small guesthouse needs only a printed QR code, so it buys no hardware. The optional reception tablet keeps recording arrivals through power and network outages and syncs when the connection returns. Host notification, approval for restricted areas, the emergency roster of who is on site, sign-out and audit evidence all run from the same record.

It connects to the systems hotels already use. Many Namibian lodges run CiMSO's INNkeeper software for bookings and front-office work, including Onguma Safari Camps at Etosha and the six properties of Journeys Namibia (Marais, 2022, 2023). Checkpoint integrates with CiMSO's INNterchange interface, so expected arrivals flow into Checkpoint as pre-registered guests and rooms map to on-site zones.

Name products or services that the innovation improves on or replaces

It replaces the shared paper guest register and the loose visitor sheets used at many hotels, lodges and tourism desks, and the practice of meeting the legal register duty with a book every later guest can read. For day visitors, contractors and walk-ins who never receive a room bill, it replaces WhatsApp lists and open spreadsheets that hold personal details with no controls.

It works beside, not instead of, hotel property management software. Cloud systems such as Hotelogix already run bookings and billing at Namibian properties, including Oshakati Country Lodge and Burning Shore Hotel, which moved from an on-premises system in 2025 (Hotelogix, 2025). CiMSO INNkeeper runs many of the country's safari lodges. Checkpoint handles the front door (who arrived, who is on site, privacy, assisted check-in and the emergency roster) and exchanges arrival data with those systems rather than competing with them.

It improves on imported visitor-management software built for office towers in well-connected markets, which assumes every visitor has a smartphone and every site a steady connection. Checkpoint is built in Namibia for QR check-in, assisted entry and offline operation. It is priced for local properties: N\$1,500 per site per month, against about N\$615 to N\$2,050 per location for Vizito and about N\$6,300 per location for Envoy's Premium plan at approximate exchange rates (Envoy, n.d.; Vizito, n.d.), with unlimited visits, local electronic funds transfer billing and Namibian support included.

What will be the social impact of this innovation?

Guests keep their privacy at the desk. Domestic travellers, regional road arrivals, older overseas guests and people without smartphones should not have to write their address or phone number on a page the next stranger reads. Assisted check-in is part of the design, which matters in a country where smartphone ownership is uneven.

Properties get ready for data protection law before it arrives. When the Data Protection Bill becomes law, properties that already collect only what they need, restrict who sees it and keep an audit trail will not have to rebuild their front desk under deadline.

Staff get a real safety tool. Lodges along the Etosha, Kunene, Sossusvlei and coastal routes need to know who is on the property when something goes wrong. Because the emergency roster comes from the same check-in records, visitor management becomes part of guest safety instead of paperwork.

It creates skilled local jobs. Every new site needs installation, front-desk training and ongoing support, and each region we enter creates technical and customer-support roles in Namibia. Small and community properties can start with no hardware to buy.

How will this innovation contribute towards environmental stewardship?

The gains are practical. Digital check-in reduces daily reliance on bound registers, photocopied identity pages and printed emergency lists. A standard setup uses the guest's own phone and a printed QR code, so most small properties never buy or power an always-on device. Digital evidence packs replace couriered paper bundles for insurers and auditors.

Remote lodges that limit generator hours keep recording arrivals offline and sync later, instead of running an always-online device at the desk. Eco-lodges and conservancy accommodation that sell environmental care to guests can show the same care for guest data.

National policy points the same way. The Namibia Tourism Board and the mobile operator MTC signed a digital transformation agreement on 19 September 2025 (TechAfrica News, 2025). Checkpoint is one practical piece of that shift at the front desk.

What is the expected economic value to be generated from this innovation in the next 5 years?

Under Award rule 16, any Award money goes to this project: the Hotel Etuna pilot and further hospitality pilots, offline hardening for remote lodges, a guest-register export that matches the Namibia Tourism Board's monthly returns, the CiMSO connection at pilot properties, and Namibian sales, installation and training capacity.

The market is every registered accommodation establishment plus the tourism desks that process arrivals. Hotels reporting to the Hospitality Association of Namibia sold 40,086 of 64,003 available rooms in July 2026, an occupancy of 62.63 percent, and the Northern region led the country at 66.43 percent (The Brief, 2026). Every occupied room began with a check-in.

PLAN	MONTHLY PRICE	INCLUDED	EACH EXTRA SITE
Site	N\$1,500	1 site, unlimited visits	Not available
Network	N\$4,500	3 sites, for lodge groups and chains	N\$950
Assure	N\$9,500	3 sites, higher-assurance settings	N\$1,500

Annual billing charges ten months for twelve. Reception tablets and near-field communication badge hardware are separate purchase or lease lines.

Five-year software revenue

Based on our published prices and go-to-market plan, assuming a blended average of N\$1,500 to N\$2,000 per site per month, mostly single properties on Site, lodge groups on Network and a few Assure sites:

YEAR	SITES	ANNUAL RECURRING REVENUE
Year 1	15 to 30	N\$0.3m to N\$0.7m
Year 2	60 to 100	N\$1.1m to N\$2.4m
Year 3	120 to 180	N\$2.2m to N\$4.3m
Year 4	200 to 280	N\$3.6m to N\$6.7m
Year 5	300 to 400	N\$5.4m to N\$9.6m

Unit economics. On our management estimates, a Site subscription costs N\$345 a month to serve (hosting, support and payment gateway fees), leaving N\$1,155 in contribution, a 77 percent margin. Fixed costs of N\$42,000 a month mean the business breaks even at 37 paying sites, early in Year 2. The Award would close the Year 1 gap while the pilots run. Properties will pay by electronic funds transfer, or by card or instant payment through our payment gateway partner.

Because pricing is per site, revenue grows with every branch a group adds. Wider value includes reception time saved, lower privacy risk for properties hosting overseas guests, faster answers to auditors and insurers, and local installation and support work, which the Hotel Etuna pilot will measure. Because every check-in is structured data, properties gain arrival analytics and busy-period forecasts, and the sector gains anonymised arrival statistics it does not have today.

How the Development Bank of Namibia can multiply this

Three introductions would let one pilot in Ongwediva become a national standard, and each one serves a goal those institutions have already set for themselves.

INTRODUCTION	WHY IT SERVES THEM	WHAT WE WOULD PROPOSE
Namibia Tourism Board	Its Chief Executive Officer has said better data will strengthen the Board's tourism data management system, "allowing it to track tourist travel trends, manage levies, and improve service delivery" (Windhoek Observer, 2025). Every property already owes the Board a guest register and monthly returns.	A pilot in which Checkpoint produces the register and monthly returns in the Board's own format, and shares aggregated, anonymised arrival statistics with the Board's tourism data system.
Hospitality Association of Namibia	Its members carry the privacy risk of the shared book and will carry the duties of the coming data protection law.	A member cohort of ten properties across regions, starting in the north, with results published to all members.
Ministry of Information and Communication Technology	The Ministry leads the Data Protection Bill and the electronic signature regulations under the Electronic Transactions Act (Ministry of Information and Communication Technology, 2025).	Checkpoint as a practical example of data protection readiness at the front desk, ahead of the Act.

The Bank's own portfolio of financed hospitality businesses is a fourth door: properties it already supports could adopt Checkpoint on the same terms as the pilot cohort.

Attachments

FORM SLOT	DOCUMENT ENCLOSED
Business model	01 Business Model
Product / technical specifications	02 Product and Technical Specifications
CVs of key individuals	03 Curriculum vitae: George Nekwaya; 03 Curriculum vitae: Etuna Nekwaya
Additional attachment	00 Entry Submission (this document)
Additional attachment	04 Vision Essay: Digital transformation starts at the reception desk
Additional attachment	05 Evidence and Sources
Additional attachment	06 Independent auditor: Thomas Paavo Hamata

Acknowledgement of Rules of the 2026/27 Innovation Award

I acknowledge that I am familiar with rules 1 to 21 of the 2026/27 Innovation Award and am bound by them in respect of my entry.

FULL NAME

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CAPACITY

Founder and authorised representative, Buffr
Financial Services CC

Abbreviations

CC	Close corporation
MTC	Mobile Telecommunications Limited
MoU	Memorandum of understanding (appears in a cited title)
N\$	Namibia dollar
NTB	Namibia Tourism Board (appears in a cited title)
QR	Quick response (a scannable code)

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